

UPSC CSE 2026: CRITICAL CURRENT AFFAIRS BRIEF



PIL: EVOLUTION AND MODERN CRITIQUE



JUDICIAL REMARKS (JUSTICE B.V. NAGARATHNA)



- Expressed concern on "PIL evolution"
- J. Nagarathna: PIL morphed into "Paisa, Publicity, Private, & Political Interest Litigation"

INDIAN YOUNG LAWYERS ASSOCIATION (IYLA) CASE



- Court questioned *locus standi* of IYLA (not "devotees") vs. "strangers" to denomination
- Debated if party with no personal stake or "conscience" should challenge

CONSTITUTIONAL BASIS

Articles 32 (SC) and 226 (HC)



JUDICIAL ACTIVISM VS. MISUSE

- Landmark reforms (e.g., Vishakha Guidelines)
- "Frivolous" PILs as "abuse of process"

WAY FORWARD



- Rigorous application of *locus standi* in religious matters
- Potentially "reconsidering" or "filtering" PIL jurisdictions



VANDE MATARAM & NATIONAL HONOUR



AMENDMENT TO 1971 ACT

- Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 amended (via 2026 Bill)
- Now includes **Vande Mataram**
- Disrespecting/disrupting singing is punishable** (up to 3 years imprisonment)

GUIDELINES

- MHA mandated: All six stanzas rendered in **3 minutes and 10 seconds** at official functions, standing in attention

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

- Composed by **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** (1875)
- Featured in **Anandamath** (1882) (Sanyasi Rebellion)
- Has **six stanzas**; historically only first two adopted due to sensitivities

STATUS

- Constitution (Article 51A) m. Flag/Anthem
- Vande Mataram's status largely customary** until these statutory protections



CANADA: ALBERTA REFERENDUM DEMAND



REFERENDUM 2026

- Scheduled: October 19, 2026
- Alberta government (Premier **Danielle Smith**) proposed **nine questions**



IMMIGRATION

- Provincial control, "reasonable fees" for non-permanent residents



KEY ISSUES

- IMMIGRATION:** Provinces can **opt-out of federal programs** (health, Funding)
- CONSTITUTIONAL REFORM:** Provinces can **opt-out of programs** (health, education) without losing federal funding
- GEOPOLITICS:**
- Reflects growing "western alienation" in Canada, challenging federal jurisdiction and fiscal arrangements



UDGAM PORTAL: RBI'S CENTRALISED SOLUTION



LAUNCH & PURPOSE

- Launched by **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)**
- Aid citizens/legal heirs to search for "unclaimed deposits" in banking system

FUNCTIONS

Search



- Search-only facility (not for claims settlement)
- Users approach respective bank with search results to claim

SCALE

- As of May 2026, **30 banks** integrated, covering approx. **90%** of unclaimed funds in the **DEAF** (Depositor Education and Awareness Fund)

LIMITATIONS



- Does not include Post Office deposits, Provident Funds (PF), Insurance policies
- Calls for integration

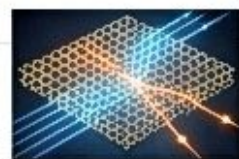
COMPREHENSIVE NOTEBOOK: EMERGING TECH & GLOBAL ENERGY TRENDS (FOR UPSC CSE 2026)

1. METAMATERIALS & AI ENGINEERING



FOCUS: PRELIMS – SCI & TECH (EMERGING TECH)

- **METAMATERIALS:** Artificially engineered materials; Properties derived from **GEOMETRY & STRUCTURE**, not chemical composition.
- **PHYSICAL LEARNING:** Physical systems (like a metamaterial) “learn” to perform tasks (e.g., stiffness adjustment) via **mechanical feedback**; mimics neural networks **WITHOUT** digital CPU.
- **SOFT ROBOTICS APPLICATION:** Creates robots with **LOCAL DECISION-MAKING**. “Intelligence” is embedded in material; responds to pressure or touch autonomously.
- **MACHINE LEARNING LINK: SELF-SUPERVISED & CONTRASTIVE LEARNING** train materials. Comparing mechanical states **optimizes** unit-cell geometry for “programmable elasticity.”

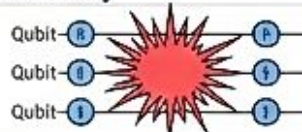


2. QUANTUM COMPUTING: NEW VULNERABILITIES



FOCUS: PRELIMS – SCI & TECH (QUANTUM MECHANICS)

- **NEW THREAT: CORRECTED PHASE ERROR BURSTS:** Errors occur in “bursts,” even with **Quantum Error Correction (QEC)**; overwhelming the system.
- **SUPERCONDUCTING QUBITS:** Made from **superconducting materials** near **absolute zero**. Sensitive industry standard.
- **INTERFERENCE MECHANISM:** Bursts often from **HIGH-ENERGY PARTICLES** (like cosmic rays) or thermal fluctuations hitting the chip, causing **WIDESPREAD DECOHERENCE**.
- **IMPACT:** Breaks assumption of independent errors; makes current error-correction protocols **less effective**.



3. GLOBAL & INDIA ENERGY LANDSCAPE (2025-26)

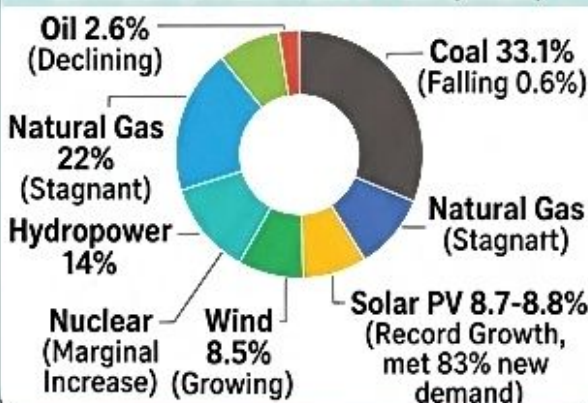


FOCUS: MAINS – GS PAPER III (ENERGY, INFRASTRUCTURE, ENV.)

A. GLOBAL ELECTRICITY MIX



GLOBAL ELECTRICITY MIX (2025)

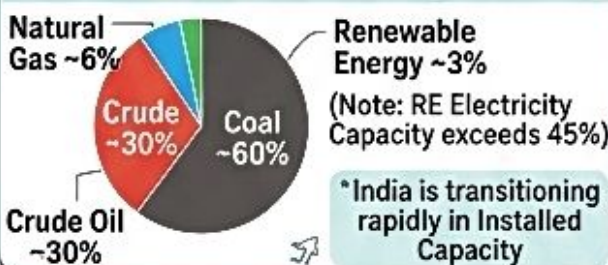


B. WHY RENEWABLE ENERGY (RE) DEMAND IS RISING?

1. **COST PARITY:** Solar/wind cheapest new bulk electricity
2. **ENERGY SECURITY:** Reduces dependence on volatile global markets (post-conflicts).
3. **“AGE OF ELECTRICITY”:** More EVs and electric heating shifting grids to clean.
4. **DECARBONIZATION COMMITMENTS:** Racing to meet COP28 goals, triple RE capacity by 2030.

C. INDIA'S ENERGY PROFILE & CRUDE OIL DYNAMICS

INDIA'S PRIMARY ENERGY MIX (ESTIMATED)



INDIA'S CRUDE OIL SOURCES (FY 2024-25)

1. **RUSSIA** (>35%, discounted pricing)
2. **IRAQ**
3. **SAUDI ARABIA**
4. **UAE**
5. **USA**



➔ **KEY TAKEAWAY:** India achieved NDC target of 40% non-fossil installed capacity ahead of schedule; now aims for 500 GW by 2030.